

9Marks and catholicity: one word, two meanings

9Marks, a respected and popular church ministry in the evangelical world, has set out to revive the word catholicity, and defines it in three words: churches partnering together. For a thousand years the word meant one visible communion, one faith, one Baptism, one Supper, one ordered ministry. Same word, two meanings, and the difference is not small, for one of them can be satisfied while every division in Christendom stands. This page lays the two side by side, from 9Marks' own essays and the first millennium's own documents, and points to where the full arguments live on this site.

Their definition, in their own words

In its journal's issue on catholicity, 9Marks president Jonathan Leeman defines the word in three words, churches partnering together, adding fairly that the three words take shortcuts, and his fuller essay supplies the doctrine. The local gathering, he writes there, is what we behold with the eyes of flesh, a manifestation or outpost of something we can only behold with the eyes of faith, namely, the catholic or universal church. And the basis is stated as doctrine: a right doctrine of catholicity, Leeman writes, is Protestant. It roots in a shared view of the gospel, not in a shared view of the ordinances or church structure. Mark Dever's historical essay concedes what was traded, for the word catholic, he reports, was a term used for exclusion and definition from the second or third century until the modern period, and Luther and Calvin re-weighted Vincent of Lérins' three tests, everywhere, always, and by all, keeping the always alone.

Read those quotations slowly, because everything on this page follows from them. The whole, in this definition, is invisible by definition, and the only church anyone can see is the congregation, so catholicity can only ever be a relation between congregations, and partnership is what remains. That is the low-church move performed on the word itself, the sacraments and the ministry removed from catholicity's definition before the conversation begins, and the reader should simply know it has happened.

And test the new meaning the way Newman taught the age to test any development, by whether it preserves the type of the thing it claims to continue. The undivided Church knew nothing of churches partnering together across a standing division. The Nestorians did not partner with the Eutychians, and neither partnered with the Great Church, for the word catholic was itself the boundary between communion and separation, and the only relation the first millennium offered a divided body was reunion. Where the old meaning names one visible communion and calls division a wound, the new one names a network and calls division weather. A definition

the whole first millennium could not have recognized is not a development of catholicity. By Newman's own first note it is a corruption, the type not preserved, wearing the old word's name.

The two meanings, side by side

The left column is from their essays. The right column is from the first millennium's own documents, whose receipts this site collects.

	9Marks	The first millennium
The question asked	How should separate gospel-preaching churches recognize and work with one another?	What has the whole Church received, and how is her visible communion kept and restored?
What catholic means	The universal gathering of all believers, beheld only by faith. Local churches are its visible outposts.	According to the whole: one visible fellowship of churches across the world, holding one faith, one Baptism, one Supper, one ordered ministry.
What can be seen	The local congregation.	The whole communion: one altar in each city, bishops known to one another by letter, councils gathered from East and West.
What it requires	Agreement on the gospel, plus partnership as occasion allows. Not a shared view of the ordinances or church structure.	The shared faith entire: creed, sacraments, ministry, morals, held everywhere, always, and by all.
Its instruments	Prayer for other churches, pulpit swaps, joint sending, speaking well of one another.	All of those, and also the synod, the letter of communion, the shared Supper, the common creed.
What division is	A standing condition to be navigated charitably.	A wound in the Body, to be healed.

The marks, side by side

The Creed's four (381)	The Reformation's three	The current nine (9Marks)	Mere catholicity
One Holy Catholic Apostolic	The word rightly preached The sacraments rightly administered Discipline exercised	Expositional preaching Gospel doctrine Conversion and evangelism Church membership Church discipline Discipleship and growth Church leadership Prayer Missions	The Holy Scriptures The Nicene Creed The christology of the seven councils Mary the Theotokos The veneration of the holy icons The apostolic succession The real presence in the Eucharist The regeneration given in Baptism The moral consensus of the Fathers

Count the overlap. None of the Creed's four appears among the nine, and of the Reformation's three, the nine keep the preaching and the discipline and drop the sacraments. Tim Challies saw it at the very beginning, laying the nine as they then stood beside the Reformation's three in the 2004 post that introduced 9Marks to his readers: glaringly absent, then, is the emphasis on the proper administration of the sacraments. He recorded Dever's answer, that most churches still place sufficient emphasis on the sacraments, so it is not a lost mark in need of recovery, and gently disagreed. Twenty years later the nine have been revised, prayer and missions added, and the Supper still did not make the list. That is not a gotcha. It is a fact about the list, and Challies saw it first. The fourth column is mere catholicity, the faith the whole Church of the first millennium confessed and practiced, graded communion by communion in part one, and the reader may run the same count against it himself.

What the word cannot mean

The gist: on their own pages, the partnership meaning leaves every wall standing, fences the Supper between the partners, and cannot be seen by the world. Four exhibits, all from the journal itself.

The walls. Their cooperation essay commends Ryle's advice: keep the walls of separation low, and shake hands over them often. Warm advice. But the walls stay. Another essay says it plainly: it's a good thing our church isn't collapsed into theirs.

The rail. Leeman opens his longest essay barred from the Supper at a Missouri Synod church. He takes it well, because his own church draws a similar line: Cheverly Baptist does not count infant baptism, so a Presbyterian cannot join without being baptized again. Partners, and fenced from one another's Supper. This site said of Rome's closed altar that the cost is an argument for healing the division, not for pretending it is healed. The same sentence falls here.

Basil. The journal's one patristic study is Basil's warm friendship with Eusebius of Samosata. Read one letter further: Basil begged Athanasius and Rome to restore visible communion in the storm-torn East. He had the friendships. He spent them on communion.

The prayer. The oneness of John 17:21 is offered as evidence to the world, and the world does not have the eyes of faith. An invisible unity cannot do the one thing the prayer says oneness is for. The fear behind all this is honorable, for these men watched Billy Graham's catholic resolve corrode a lifetime's clarity, and they chose truth over togetherness rightly. But the first millennium was not the tolerant option. Its unity bound more than the gospel, not less.

Where the arguments live

None of these arguments is carried here, because each is carried in full elsewhere on this site, and this page's only job was the two definitions.

- What the word meant and who held it: part one, the historic communions.
- Whether the first churches were low churches: part two's record.
- Where the Bible's table of contents came from: part two's canon section.
- Acts 15 and church order: part two's verses.
- The Supper: part one's presence note and objections 5 through 8.
- The fifty objections a 9Marks reader brings: part three entire.

What would change

The first ask is the smallest, and it is about the word. A ministry may commend churches partnering together, and the practice is good, but partnership has honest names of its own, cooperation, fellowship, brotherhood, and catholicity is not one of them. Words cannot be redefined and kept, only borrowed against, so let the practice be called what it is, and let the word keep the meaning it carried for a thousand years, until the thing it names is wanted again. The rest of the ask is what wanting it would look like. Nothing in the nine marks needs to be given up, for every one is a recovered piece of the ancient discipline. The first millennium would add the Creed's four marks beside the nine, so that contentment with permanent separation reads as a health problem the way absent discipline does, would seat the Supper among the marks at the center of the first day of the week, and would treat the partnerships already built as scaffolding for communion, the way Basil's friendships were. None of that is a small ask, and the same scale of ask stands on this site's front page, addressed to Rome and the East. The word means the whole. Take up the whole, and the word comes with it: that they all may be one, that the world may believe (John 17:21).

Quod ubique, quod semper, quod ab omnibus.

Scripture quotations are from the King James Version unless otherwise noted.